

ANI



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with the subjects being discussed. So, in their individual essays, they provide a primer, including a short-hand history, of a sector or topic before analysing the current situation and outlining innovative solutions.

Singh's forte is in dealing with issues of finance and the economy, apart from governance. Having served in the prime minister's office, one of his essays analyses how, over the years, the PMO has overshadowed the important role of the cabinet secretary, to the detriment of governance. He opines that in today's fast-moving and complex world the approach as to which office has the last word on what reaches the PM is both outdated and ineffective. He talks of the need for a 'next-gen' PMO that would be able to anticipate uncertainties while remaining connected with realities to enable it to rapidly respond to challenges. Instead of a mindset of hierarchy, he says, there is a need to shift to complementarity and equality between the PMO and the cabinet secretariat. Calling for reforms in the finance ministry, too, he narrates how Dr Manmohan Singh, when he was taking his leave as the finance minister in the mid-'90s, asked him, "What do you think honestly is my failing?" When Singh looked perplexed by the question, Manmohan answered it himself saying, "The two entities which remain totally unreformed are the ministry of finance and the RBI. Regrettably, I have headed both these institutions."

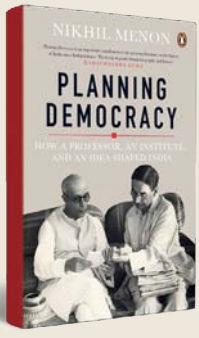
When it comes to disaster management, P.K. Mishra is internationally recognised as one of the top experts. He was lauded for the way he went about arranging relief and rehabilitation for victims of the 2001 Bhuj earthquake and developing a manual for dealing with such disasters. Years later, he would become central to the handling of the Covid pandemic by the Modi government. In his essay, he says that "whole of government" and "whole of society" approaches are the best recipe for success while dealing with major disasters. In another essay, Mishra narrates personal anecdotes of being a young IAS officer in Gujarat, including dealing with recalcitrant politicians. His learning: For rapid development to happen, there is need for constructive and harmonious relationship between politicians, bureaucrats and citizens. He quotes Balwantrai Mehta, a former Gujarat chief minister, who once said, "The Panchayati Raj system would succeed if officials do not behave like non-officials and non-officials do not behave like officials!"

Both authors in their essays deal with a vast range of subjects, including federalism and the Centre, the emergence of urban local bodies and rural panchayats as the third tier of governance, the ways to transform agriculture, technology and its future role in education, the architecture of a new health policy, dealing with climate goals and analysing the fiscal matrix. Many of the essays are based on their speeches, lectures and articles, which they have expanded on here. The value of the book lies in its central theme that paradigms of the past need to be recalibrated and the reforms required must be put in place. ■



SAMAAJ SARKAR BAZAAR: A Citizen-First Approach
by Rohini Nilekani
NOTION PRESS,
284pages,
₹**349**

The billionaire-philanthropist's essays on her 'samaaj-first' vision for restoring balance between the three pillars of the state, markets and society. Her faith in Indian civil society is heartening: 'The more one group in Samaaj has tried to dominate the narrative, the more other groups have risen up to balance the equation.'



PLANNING DEMOCRACY: How a Professor, an Institute, and an Idea Shaped India
by Nikhil Menon
PENGUIN VIKING,
Pg **360,**
₹**799**

An account of another experiment to fix the state-society-economy equation: 60 years of five-year plans, and P.C. Mahalanobis, the man behind it. While the dissolution of the Planning Commission has left a taint of failure on it, this is a reminder of its legacy and some of its arguably imperiled virtues, like high-quality data.